

## IN CONTEXT

### Palestrina and the Counter-Reformation

In the 16th century, provoked by the Protestant Reformation, the Catholic Church embarked on a Counter-Reformation to remedy lax practices and reinvigorate the faith. In the 1560s, Catholic divines meeting at the Council of Trent discussed banning music from church services, arguing that it distracted worshippers with sensual pleasure. There is a legend that a performance of Palestrina's *Missa Papae Marcelli* so moved the church dignitaries that they changed their minds. Although the legend itself is not true, Palestrina's music did in the long run satisfy the Church that chaste spiritual music could indeed reinforce Catholic faith.

Born Giovanni Pierluigi around 1525, the composer became known as Palestrina after the name of the town of his birth, just outside Rome. As a child, he sang in the choir at Rome's prestigious basilica of Santa Maria Maggiore. By the age of 20, he had been appointed director of music at Palestrina cathedral, and six or so years later, he was invited by Pope Julius III to head the choir at St. Peter's Basilica, which involved writing sacred music and directing its performance. Palestrina's first book of Masses was published in 1554.